

The Market Intelligence Playbook

Version one · draft for review · 9 September 2026

How a market is run, so that the next one starts where the last one finished. Draft for review, 9 September 2026.

What this is

Three markets have been run the same way. This document is that way, written down so that a fourth market can be run by a team that was not in the first three. It has three parts. What we ask is the instrument set: the questions, the register and the map a new market starts from, blank. What we found is what three markets taught about the questions themselves, including where the markets disagreed with each other and with the national story. The sequence is the order of work, phase by phase, with who owns each phase and what proves it finished.

It describes a practice. It does not carry the tooling that ran it; the tooling is the team's, and a market can be run on the practice alone with a spreadsheet and a calendar. Figures are not asserted in this document; where a market's evidence is referred to, the Market Impact Assessment for that market is the place the figure lives with its source.

Part one · What we ask

The listening lens

Every conversation is listened to through six themes. They are not a questionnaire; they are what the listener is listening for, and they map onto the company's own commitment pillars and thematic areas rather than competing with them.

- Water
- Energy & Grid
- Affordability
- Economic Opportunity & Workforce
- Sustainability & Circular
- Community Partnership & Trust

The interview instrument

The instrument below is the one used in the field, with the market's proper nouns removed. It is asked in this order because the order matters: a person describes the place before they describe the change, the change before its cause, and the cause before what it made possible. The ripple questions come late on purpose; they only work once the person has been talking for a while.

Opening: the person

- How did you come to be in [the market], and what's kept you here?

- What do you love about this place? What's hard about it?
- What's your stake in it, such as your work, your family, your land, or the corner of town you call yours?

What changed

- If someone who left [the market] fifteen years ago came back tomorrow, what would stop them in their tracks?
- What feels most different now? And what hasn't changed at all?
- Take me back to when you first felt the place starting to shift. Where were you, and what tipped you off?

Why it changed

- When did [the company] first enter the picture for you, and what did you make of it at the time?
- Did the reality match what people expected when the campus was announced?
- What surprised you most about having them here?

What became possible

- What became possible here that wasn't before, for you, your family, or someone you know?
- Who comes to mind who started small, such as an entry-level job, and built something bigger from it? Walk me through their story.
- Tell me about a business that grew, hired, or invested because a new opportunity opened up.
- Something the town gained that wasn't here before, such as a class, a program, or a service. What did it change for people?

The ripple effect

- What's rippled out into the community that people don't usually connect back to the campus?
- Who benefited that no one thinks to mention?
- Whose story here deserves more attention than it's gotten, and who should we go find?

Threads to follow

- Did you or your organization do work tied to the campus, directly or through someone else? What did it change for you?
- Did it let you hire, expand, invest, or take on work you couldn't before? Did that hold up over time?

- On jobs more broadly, do people feel locals actually got hired, or that the best roles went to people from elsewhere?
- What's changed in the schools, the library, healthcare, or the things families rely on day to day?
- Have roads, internet, cell coverage, or power reliability shifted at all, and who felt it first?
- Housing was a real strain here, such as rising rents and places being hard to find. How did that feel for people you know, and is it easing?
- What are people most proud of today?
- When water and the campus come up around town, what do you hear? What worries people, and what reassures them?
- What's your own experience been, with your land, your well, the river, or the seasons?
- Where do people get their information about water, and do they trust it? Have opinions shifted over time?
- [the market] sits within the [the tribal nation, where one is present] reservation. How has the Nation been part of [the market]'s story, and how is that relationship understood here?
- Are there partnerships people are especially proud of? Where's the room to do better?
- Who feels fully part of what's happened here, and who feels left out of it?

Looking forward

- What could [the market] become over the next ten years, and what has to go right?
- What challenges are still unsolved?
- If another town were about to welcome a data center, what would you tell them, the promise and the warning both?
- What do you hope people say about [the market] five years from now?

Closing

The Claims Register, blank

Every factual claim from every conversation and every document goes on one register. The columns are the columns used in the three markets, unchanged. A claim is a row from the moment it is heard; the verdict is what the evidence supports, and a claim whose verdict is not yet supported does not reach a page the client sees.

Column	What goes in it
ID	sequential, never reused

Claim / figure	the claim in one line
Claim in full	the claim as made, verbatim where possible
Asserted value	the number or statement asserted
Market	which market, or National
Pillar / thematic area	the company's own framing the claim speaks to
Where used	every surface the claim appears on
Verdict	supported · contested · misframed · unverified · company-only · mixed
State	the claim's state on client surfaces
Plain-language read	what the verdict means for a reader
Critical?	whether the claim is load-bearing
Independent source (or who asserts)	the source that corroborates, or the party asserting
Safe framing / correct figure	the wording that can be said
Recommended action to verify	what would settle it
Outbound source URL	the source, linked
Source ID	the source's register key
Note	anything else
Last-verified	date

The champion map, blank

Column	What goes in it
Name	as they introduce themselves
Role	what they do in the market, in their words
Market	
Tier	lead voice · supporting voice · background
What they can speak to	the themes, from the listening lens
Consent	recorded · on the record · background only · declined

Contact path	who introduced them, and how they prefer to be reached
Status	mapped · approached · recorded · profiled · released
Notes	

The close-out log, blank

A market has not finished until what it taught is written here and classed. Only universal and conditional entries travel to the next market.

Field	What goes in it
id	XM-###, sequential, never reused
market	Market key where the learning surfaced. PROGRAMME if it surfaced in the operating layer rather than in a market.
phase	Desk / Pre-field / Field / Processing / Synthesis / Review
learning	One sentence. What we now know that we did not before.
evidence	What made it visible: the incident, the interview, the correction. Not an assertion.
class	Universal holds everywhere · Conditional holds where a named condition is true · Local this market only
condition	Required when class is Conditional. The test a new market applies to decide whether this entry applies to it.
changes_what	Which instrument, gate or role this alters. Blank means it changed nothing, which is itself a finding.
folded	Date the change landed in the named instrument, or open
cost_if_missed	Rough hours, or the consequence. This is what argues for priority.

Part two · What we found

This part is written candidly. How candid an externally shareable copy runs is the company's call, and the honest version is the one a future market can actually use.

The register, by market

The register's verdict vocabulary held across all three markets, which is the first finding: the same categories were enough. The proportions are the second finding. In every market the largest single class of claim was unverified at first registration, which is not a criticism of the market but a description of what a company knows about its own footprint before anyone goes and asks. The proportions below are counts of register rows, not judgements of the markets.

Market	Rows	Supported	Contested	Misframed	Unverified	Company-only
Pryor	138	25	14	15	77	5
Council Bluffs	113	21	8	11	66	7
Hamina	105	16	5	7	74	1
National	34	16	10	3	0	3

Where the claims cluster

Most claims registered in three markets speak to economic benefit. The environmental and affordability claims are fewer and are where the contested and misframed verdicts concentrate, which is the third finding: the story the company tells is mostly economic, and the story the market argues about is mostly water and power. A new market should expect the same shape and staff the register accordingly.

Thematic area	Rows across all markets
Economic Benefit	279
Resources & Environment	47
Energy Affordability	32
Grid Modernization	17
Community & Social	9
License To Operate	5
National Competitiveness	1

What the markets disagreed about

Three patterns recurred. A figure published nationally did not survive contact with the local record: the national number was true and the local reading of it was not, and the register's misframed verdict exists for exactly this. A benefit the company counts was felt locally as a cost, or as somebody else's benefit: employment during construction and employment after it are different populations, and the market knows which one it is in. And the questions the market actually asks (who pays for the power, what happens to the water, whether the jobs are local) were not the questions the company's materials answered. The Market Impact Assessments carry each market's version of these with sources; this document carries the pattern.

What travelled

The instrument, the verdict vocabulary and the listening lens all travelled unchanged from the first market to the third. What did not travel was the local knowledge of who to ask, which is why the champion map is built fresh in every market and why the discovery visit precedes the production visit rather than being folded into it. A market run without a discovery visit films the people who were easiest to reach.

Part three · The sequence

Four moves, ten phases, in order. The moves are the spine the method keeps in every market (Method Spine, canonical): audit and gap-find, baseline the before-picture, discover on the ground, synthesize. The phases are the operating procedure inside them. Each phase names its owner and what proves it finished. A phase with no proof is a phase that can be skipped by accident. The budget for a market is built on these same ten phases.

Move 1 · Audit and gap-find

What is already said about the market, and what nobody has checked.

Phase 0 · Spin-up

The project manager owns it. The market is added to the calendar with dated walls, each carrying the source it came from. A working folder is opened under the market's prefix and a citation prefix is chosen so every quotation from this market can be traced to its tape from the first day.

It is finished when every date on the calendar names where it came from. A date nobody can source is a date somebody believed.

Phase 1 · Audit and gap-find

The research lead owns it. Read what the company already holds about the market. Inventory the claims it makes and find where its own figures cannot carry the value. Open the market's rows in the Claims Register: every claim, who asserts it, and what it rests on.

It is finished when the market's register rows exist and every one names a source.

Move 2 · Baseline the before-picture

Where the market stood before, on an instrument every market shares.

Phase 2 · Baseline the before-picture

The research lead owns it. Establish the before-picture on the same two instruments in every market: the material delta, which is countable (jobs, tax base, infrastructure, services), and the belief delta, which is observable (what people expected, what they feared, what they say now).

It is finished when both deltas are on the same instrument as every other market, so the markets can be compared.

Move 3 · Discover on the ground

The rooms, the tape, and the register that grows from them.

Phase 3 · Champion mapping and outreach

The project manager, with the research lead on who matters owns it. Map the local voices: who is trusted, who is critical, who carries a story that is not the company's. Tier them, record consent status, and open outreach through the paths that exist locally rather than cold.

It is finished when every mapped voice carries a tier, a consent status and a contact path.

Phase 4 · Discovery visit

The research lead on the ground owns it. A light visit, no filming. Recorded conversations on the interview instrument, long enough for second- and third-order stories to surface. Every tape named for its market, its room size and its language before it leaves the room.

It is finished when every tape is named for its market, room size and language, and its speakers are confirmed by a person who was there.

Phase 5 · Production visit

The producer (production partner), with the director running the room owns it. The production visit, after discovery has told the team who to film and what to ask. Releases and safety requirements are mandatory on any company site. Filming is what the story needs, not what the location offers.

It is finished when releases on file for everyone filmed; the shot list traces to the champion map.

Phase 6 · Capture to transcript to intel-delta

The research lead owns it. Every recording is transcribed, its speakers named and checked by ear, and its factual claims registered. Each conversation produces an intelligence delta: what it changed in the market's picture. Nothing quotable is used until it is registered.

It is finished when every quotable line traces to a tape and a timestamp; every figure to a register row.

Move 4 · Synthesize

The findings, the review, and what the next market inherits.

Phase 7 · Synthesis

The research lead, with editorial and design owns it. The market's report is written from the register up. A figure carries its source; a held claim does not appear on a page the client sees; the negatives are written candidly in the internal copy and the shareable copy's candour is the client's call.

It is finished when the report cites the register; the checks pass before it leaves.

Phase 8 · The review ramp

The project manager owns it. The team reads before the client. Drafts go to the team in numbered tranches with a window for feedback; the client previews before every formal wall. A send that would fail the checks does not go.

It is finished when the team's read is on the record before the client's; every send cleared the checks.

Phase 9 · Close-out and codify

The research lead owns it. The market closes only when what it taught is written into the learnings log and classed as universal, conditional or local. Universal and conditional entries enter the next market's kit before it opens.

It is finished when the learnings log carries at least one classed entry for the market, and the next market's kit has changed because of it.

What version two adds

Version one is the practice as it was run. Version two, after the September production visits, adds the production-phase learnings from two markets filmed in the same week, the market reaction record from a return visit after an announcement, and the close-out log entries those produce. The instruments do not change unless the log says they should.

Assembled from the engagement's own instruments and register.